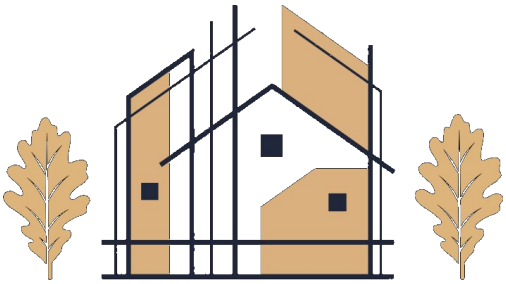

Walk-Through & Win

The 200-Point Home Inspection Checklist
Every Buyer Should Use Before Making an Offer

Spot deal breakers · Negotiate smarter · Never get blindsided

● DEAL BREAKER	● NEGOTIATE	● MONITOR
Walk away or require full fix before closing	Real cost — get quotes and negotiate off price	Not urgent — track, ask about age or budget

How to Use This Checklist

This checklist was built by a licensed home inspector with hands-on experience in electrical systems, structural evaluation, and residential inspections across hundreds of properties. It is designed to give **you — the buyer** — the knowledge to walk through any home with confidence, whether or not you've hired an inspector.

Use it at every showing. Walk each room systematically. Mark each item as you go. Note anything that concerns you and bring it up with your inspector — or use it to decide whether a property is even worth pursuing.

This checklist does **not replace a licensed home inspection.** A professional inspector uses specialized tools — thermal cameras, moisture meters, gas detectors, electrical testers — and accesses areas you may not. But it gives you the vocabulary, the awareness, and the confidence to ask the right questions and catch what others miss.

> ***PRO TIP FROM ELEVATION INSPECTIONS:*** *Before your walkthrough, bring an outlet tester ($8 at any hardware store), a flashlight, and your phone. Take photos of every red flag. If a seller won't let you open the electrical panel or access the attic — that itself is a red flag.*

EXTERIOR & FOUNDATION

■	Horizontal cracks in foundation walls — indicates lateral soil pressure	DEAL BREAKER
■	Vertical or stair-step cracks in foundation — monitor for movement	NEGOTIATE
■	Efflorescence (white chalky residue) on foundation — water intrusion sign	NEGOTIATE
■	Foundation settling or heaving visible from outside	NEGOTIATE
■	Gaps between foundation sill plate and framing above	DEAL BREAKER
■	Grading slopes TOWARD the house — must drain away (6" drop per 10 ft)	DEAL BREAKER
■	Window wells: clogged, no drain visible, or sitting below soil level	NEGOTIATE
■	Exterior walls: bulging, cracking, or spalling brick/block	NEGOTIATE
■	Siding: rot, warping, missing sections, improper overlap at bottom	NEGOTIATE
■	Wood-to-soil contact anywhere on structure (termite and rot pathway)	DEAL BREAKER
■	Gaps around all utility penetrations — gas, electric, plumbing entries	NEGOTIATE
■	Retaining walls: leaning, no weep holes, gaps in mortar joints	NEGOTIATE
■	Driveway or walkways heaving toward the structure	MONITOR
■	Vegetation growing against foundation or underneath siding	NEGOTIATE

WINDOWS, DOORS & GARAGE

Double-pane windows: fogging between panes = failed seal	NEGOTIATE
All windows open, close, latch, and lock properly	MONITOR
Bedroom egress windows: minimum 5.7 sq ft clear opening required by code	DEAL BREAKER
Exterior door frames: daylight visible around edges = air and water leak	NEGOTIATE
Doors stick or bind — can signal foundation movement or settling	NEGOTIATE
Garage door auto-reverse: place 2x4 flat under door, must reverse on contact	DEAL BREAKER
Garage door opener: wall button, remotes, and keypad all functional	MONITOR
Garage-to-living-space door: must be solid core, steel, or 20-min fire-rated	DEAL BREAKER
Garage-to-living-space door: must be self-closing and self-latching	DEAL BREAKER
Garage floor: major cracks, oil stains, drain present and clear	MONITOR
Sliding glass doors: track clear, rollers smooth, lock fully engages	MONITOR

ROOF & ATTIC

Shingles: missing, curling, cracking, or heavy granule loss in gutters	NEGOTIATE
Estimated roof age — asphalt roofs last 20–25 years (ask for permits)	NEGOTIATE
Multiple shingle layers at edge — max 2 layers allowed by most codes	NEGOTIATE
Flashing at chimney, valleys, skylights, and pipe boots — no gaps	DEAL BREAKER
Chimney: mortar joints intact, cap present, no caulk used as flashing substitute	NEGOTIATE
Chimney liner: visible, intact, correct type for fuel used	NEGOTIATE
Gutters: properly pitched toward downspouts, secured, no sagging	NEGOTIATE
Downspouts: discharge minimum 6 feet from foundation	NEGOTIATE
Attic accessible — note if access hatch is insulated and weather-stripped	MONITOR
Attic insulation: adequate depth — R-38 to R-60 depending on climate zone	NEGOTIATE
Attic ventilation: ridge vent + soffit vents balanced, no blocking	NEGOTIATE
Attic roof deck: NO daylight visible through boards or decking	DEAL BREAKER
Attic: active water staining, mold, or wet/compressed insulation present	DEAL BREAKER
Bathroom/kitchen exhaust fans: must vent OUTSIDE, not into attic space	DEAL BREAKER
Knob-and-tube wiring in attic — often makes home uninsurable	DEAL BREAKER

■	Roof deck soft spots or bounce when walked (if inspector accesses roof)	DEAL BREAKER

■ ELECTRICAL — READ EVERY LINE

■	Panel brand: Federal Pacific (Stab-Lok) — known breaker failure history	DEAL BREAKER
■	Panel brand: Zinsco or GTE-Sylvania — known breaker failure history	DEAL BREAKER
■	Panel brand: Pushmatic — obsolete, replacement parts unavailable	DEAL BREAKER
■	Double-tapped breakers: two wires on one breaker not rated for it	DEAL BREAKER
■	Oversized breakers: 30A breaker protecting 14-gauge wire = fire risk	DEAL BREAKER
■	Breakers: feel loose, won't reset, or show heat discoloration or burn marks	DEAL BREAKER
■	Open knockouts in panel box — shock and pest entry hazard	NEGOTIATE
■	Main disconnect: labeled, accessible, not blocked, within 6.5 ft of floor	MONITOR
■	Service size: 100-amp service is underpowered for modern homes	NEGOTIATE
■	Aluminum branch circuit wiring (silver-colored) — requires CO/ALR devices	DEAL BREAKER
■	Aluminum wiring at outlets: look for purple COPALUM crimps or CO/ALR markings	DEAL BREAKER
■	GFCI protection: all kitchen, bath, garage, outdoor, and basement outlets	DEAL BREAKER
■	AFCI protection: required in bedrooms for homes permitted after 2002	NEGOTIATE
■	Outlets: 3-prong ungrounded — test with outlet tester (shows open ground)	NEGOTIATE
■	Outlets: reverse polarity — hot and neutral swapped (outlet tester shows this)	NEGOTIATE
■	Two-prong outlets throughout — indicates pre-1960s ungrounded wiring	NEGOTIATE
■	Extension cords used as permanent wiring anywhere in the home	DEAL BREAKER
■	Wiring improperly stapled, hanging loose in basement or crawlspace	NEGOTIATE
■	Junction boxes: all must have covers, be accessible, not buried in walls	NEGOTIATE
■	Smoke detectors: within 10 ft of every bedroom door, one on every level	DEAL BREAKER
■	Carbon monoxide detectors: required on every level with sleeping areas	DEAL BREAKER
■	Dryer outlet: 4-prong NEMA 14-30 required in homes built after 1996	NEGOTIATE
■	Bathroom exhaust fan: present and vented outside, not just to attic	DEAL BREAKER

PLUMBING

	Water heater age: check label — gas 8–12 yrs, electric 10–15 yrs	NEGOTIATE
	TPR valve: present and piped down to floor or outside	DEAL BREAKER
	Water heater: no rust, corrosion, or water stains around base	NEGOTIATE
	Main water shut-off: locate it — is it accessible and operational?	MONITOR
	Water pressure: ideal range 40–80 PSI (ask inspector to test)	NEGOTIATE
	All faucets: run hot and cold, check for adequate pressure and drainage	MONITOR
	Under-sink cabinets: water stains, soft flooring, active drips present	NEGOTIATE
	Toilets: flush strong, fill completely, no rocking at base (wax ring)	NEGOTIATE
	Shower/tub: grout and caulk intact — no gaps at corners or pan edges	NEGOTIATE
	Shower pan: no flex or soft spots underfoot (tile over failed pan)	NEGOTIATE
	Visible supply pipes: galvanized steel = likely near end of life	NEGOTIATE
	Visible supply pipes: polybutylene gray plastic (PB) — history of failures	DEAL BREAKER
	Drain pipes: PVC, ABS, or cast iron acceptable — orangeburg = replace now	DEAL BREAKER
	Sump pump: present in basement/crawlspace? Runs when tested?	NEGOTIATE
	Sump pump discharge line goes outside and away from foundation	NEGOTIATE
	Water stains on ceilings below bathrooms — active or old leak	NEGOTIATE

HVAC — HEATING & COOLING

	Furnace age: gas furnaces last 15–20 years, electric 20–30 years	NEGOTIATE
	Furnace: run it regardless of season — feel for heat at all registers	NEGOTIATE
	Furnace heat exchanger: cracked exchanger = carbon monoxide risk	DEAL BREAKER
	Furnace filter: note condition — tells you how well home was maintained	MONITOR
	Furnace flue pipe: properly pitched upward, joints secured, no rust holes	DEAL BREAKER
	Air conditioning: run it — cool air should reach all rooms within 5 minutes	NEGOTIATE
	AC condenser (outside): fins clean, no vegetation within 2 ft, level pad	MONITOR
	Ductwork: visible sections insulated in unconditioned spaces	NEGOTIATE
	Ductwork: no disconnected runs — check basement/crawl for fallen ducts	NEGOTIATE
	All supply and return registers present and unblocked in each room	MONITOR

Gas lines: no flexible corrugated in attic (older CSST requires bonding)	NEGOTIATE
Fireplace: damper opens/closes, firebox intact, no excessive creosote	NEGOTIATE

INTERIOR — STRUCTURE & FINISHES

Floors: soft spots, excessive bounce, or sloping more than 1" per 8 ft	NEGOTIATE
Ceilings: water stains (brown rings), bubbling paint, or sagging sections	NEGOTIATE
Walls: large diagonal cracks from corners of windows or doors	NEGOTIATE
Walls: horizontal cracks in basement or lower-level walls — serious	DEAL BREAKER
Stairs: handrail present and secured, no more than 4" between balusters	DEAL BREAKER
Basement: any water entry — staining, efflorescence, musty odor	NEGOTIATE
Crawlspace: vapor barrier present and in good condition on floor	NEGOTIATE
Crawlspace: standing water, soft joists, or mold on wood framing	DEAL BREAKER
Bathroom ventilation: fan present, vents outside, adequate CFM	NEGOTIATE
Kitchen: range hood vents outside (not recirculating)	MONITOR
Dryer duct: rigid or semi-rigid metal, maximum 25 ft to exterior	DEAL BREAKER
Garage: CO detector near sleeping areas above or adjacent to garage	DEAL BREAKER

QUESTIONS TO ASK BEFORE CLOSING

How old is the roof, and is there a transferable warranty?	MONITOR
Have any insurance claims been filed on this property?	MONITOR
Are there open permits or unpermitted additions/conversions?	DEAL BREAKER
Has a sewer scope inspection ever been done?	NEGOTIATE
Any history of flooding, water intrusion, or mold remediation?	DEAL BREAKER
What is the age and service history of all HVAC systems?	NEGOTIATE
Any known underground oil tanks, wells, or septic systems?	DEAL BREAKER
Has the home been tested for radon? Results available?	NEGOTIATE
Any easements, encroachments, or deed restrictions on the property?	MONITOR
Has the property ever had a pest or termite inspection?	NEGOTIATE
What work was done without a licensed contractor?	NEGOTIATE

Your Next Steps

1

Hire an independent inspector — not your realtor's referral.

Ask: Are you licensed? Do you carry E&O; insurance? Can I attend the inspection? How long is the report? Your realtor's preferred inspector has an incentive to keep the deal alive. Find your own through ASHI (ashi.org) or InterNACHI (nachi.org).

2

Don't waive your inspection without a backup plan.

In competitive markets, buyers feel pressured to waive inspections. Even then, you can request a pre-offer walkthrough or hire a single-trade specialist — electrician, roofer, plumber — to evaluate the highest-risk systems. These targeted inspections are often still allowed even when full inspections are waived.

3

Use your findings to negotiate — not just walk away.

Every deal-breaker item has a dollar value. A panel replacement is $3,000–$8,000. A new roof is $8,000–$20,000. Get contractor quotes and request credits at closing rather than asking for repairs — you choose the contractor and control the quality.

4

Get an electrical specialist if you flagged anything in the Electrical section.

Federal Pacific panels, aluminum wiring, and double-tapped breakers aren't always caught at the same depth by every inspector. A licensed electrician can do a targeted electrical-only inspection for $150–$300. Given the fire risk involved, it is worth every penny.

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